

‘INDIA MUST DECARBONISE AND ADAPT TO REACH NET ZERO’

WITHOUT THE USE OF APPROPRIATE TECHNOLOGIES, THE COUNTRY CANNOT ACHIEVE CLIMATE SUSTAINABILITY, SAYS UNDP’S USHA RAO-MONARI

BY NIDHI SINGAL

REDUCING CARBON EMISSIONS is a global priority.

Finance, investment and new technologies are needed to reduce greenhouse gases and keep global warming in check. Usha Rao-Monari, Associate Administrator of the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), in an interaction with *Business Today*, talks about climate change, the need for climate finance and what India should focus on. Edited excerpts:

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At COP27, there was an emphatic warning that we are speeding towards catastrophic climate change. Even with so much happening, what are we lacking?

It’s a complicated question, and the answer will also be complicated, but allow me to simplify it. Somehow climate, climate concepts, and climate finance have all managed to stay at an obscure, convoluted level. The ‘how’ has prevented us from accomplishing some of the necessary goals.

In terms of climate finance, decarbonisation [that reduces greenhouse gas emissions and carbon intensity] or mitigation has received 95 per cent of the attention, which is appropriate. Adaptation [that involves changing behaviour, systems, lifestyles, economies, and the environment with a view to mitigate climate change] is a topic to which people have not given as much thought. In the last two COPs, adaptability has finally gained greater attention. Currently, 5-7 per cent of climate finance funds go towards for adapta-

tion. That’s nothing. The UN wants to increase it to at least 25 per cent of climate finance and eventually to 50 per cent. Adaptation over decarbonisation is a different kind of agenda. The two have to run parallel.

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Do you think if action is taken now, and if funds are available, we can meet the 2030 and 2050 targets?

I do. Certainly, it’s aspirational, but it’s also rooted in the knowledge of what I know is already going on. Maybe it’s the fear of deviating too far away from 1.5 [° C; limiting Earth’s warming to 1.5° C]. Maybe it’s the emergence of new approaches among various players in the world, but I think we will reach the 2030 [target] with the outcomes we set for ourselves and then 2050; or somewhere around 2050.

Why I’m optimistic is the seriousness with which countries and stakeholders are taking on this challenge. It’s no longer—‘Oh, it’s out there. It’s not going to hit me. When it hits me, I worry about it’—it’s not like that anymore. I think there’s a lot of seriousness, so we will [reach the target].

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Some reports say that around \$92 trillion would be required by 2050 towards climate change and net zero. Where will this finance come from?

There are so many numbers. And it’s not that I don’t believe in numbers, but I don’t want to focus too